Later, when I was fully alert, I signed a letter reclaiming the presidency from George while Nancy began decorating my room with pictures brought from home. Didn't I say she's a nest builder? The pictures made things better, but I was in a lot of discomfort through the weekend and didn't get much sleep. Again remembering W. C. Fields's famous line, I once thought to myself, "All in all, I'd rather be at Camp David."

Wasn't it a coincidence, I thought, that my brother had had virtually the same operation less than two weeks before me?

On Monday, after it was brought over from the White House, I wrote in my diary: "Nancy came with more pictures and brought me up to date on messages, flowers, etc. This morning, though, I went back to sleep and did pretty well until noon. It turns out there were cancer cells in the tissue they are checking. But they swear they got it all. It means, however, I'll have to have annual checks for the next five years.

"Monday night was miserable. I kept waking up and felt I'd had no good sleep at all. Did some walking around."

On Tuesday, Don Regan came by and we did a little office business. Nancy brought in more pictures and hung them on the walls. As always—as she had been for more than thirty years—she was there to unfurl that lovely smile at me when I needed her, looking fresh, radiant, and beautiful. What a lucky man I am.

Soon, Nancy had the walls almost fully covered with framed color photos of the ranch, Camp David, and our family. Outside my room, there were bouquets and flower arrangements sent by well-wishers from around the world. "They really help," I wrote at the time. "I've taken some short walks down the hall. Nancy visited the children's ward and gave them some balloons that were sent and the flowers. The children responded with home made cards.